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Liang Shi's car stood横blocking the middle of the road, the rear wheels having left a circle of black marks on the ground from the powerful impact of the emergency brake.

Daoist Yun Yin's black car was less than half a meter away from hers.

The slightest carelessness would have caused them to collide.

But this distance was precisely calculated by Liang Shi—just right.

The driver was still shaken, not yet recovered from the terror of nearly crashing, when he saw a woman in a white shirt and black pants standing there, her temperament cold and sharp, her brows and eyes cool and distant.

She held onto the car door with one hand, her gaze fixed directly on Yun Yin sitting in the back seat.

Yun Yin had already shrunk to the other side of the car, his hand resting on the door handle.

The instant he opened the door, Liang Shi extended her long arm and grabbed the back of his loose Daoist robe by the neck, using eighty percent of her strength without any mercy.

The loose collar of the Daoist robe was somewhat like a V-neck; when force was applied, it would bunch together and tighten around the neck from both sides, easily cutting off one's breath.

Yun Yin was over fifty years old with average physical fitness, and his face turned red in an instant.

Liang Shi knelt with one knee on the soft car seat, her voice growing even colder, "Get out of the car."

She increased the force in her grip, "Don't make me say it a third time."

It wasn't a threat, yet it was more threatening than one.

Seeing this, the driver was stunned for a moment, then took out his phone to call the police.

Liang Shi spoke coldly, "I'm just looking for Daoist Yun Yin for a chat. We're old friends."

The last few words sounded eerie, not at all like old friends.

After saying this, Liang Shi directly dragged and pulled Yun Yin out of the car.

Female Alphas had great strength, and Liang Shi regularly did strength training. Hauling a short, thin man wasn't too difficult for her.

"You, you, you..." After breathing in fresh air, Yun Yin managed a few words before immediately breaking into a coughing fit, as if he was about to cough up his lungs.

Liang Shi lightly rubbed her fingertips together, gave a casual flick, and pulled out an unsharpened knife from her dress pants pocket, casually playing with it in her hand.

To better embody her character, she had already practiced with this knife hundreds of times.

She had developed beautiful flourishes with it.

Her knife-spinning was especially clean and crisp.

Her eyes swept over lightly, and the cold sunlight refracted into her light brown pupils, making her appear extremely indifferent.

It shrouded her entire being in a thick aura of world-weariness.

As if she could drag you into hell at any moment.

Her appearance and temperament alone gave off an intense sense of oppression.

Yun Yin looked much older than in the original host's memories, appearing quite frail.

That immortal, otherworldly demeanor¹ from before had completely vanished in the face of life and death; only fear and terror remained in his eyes.

"You... you... don't come any closer." Yun Yin had been dragged and thrown to the ground by Liang Shi, unable to speak coherently.

Liang Shi half-crouched in front of him, "So you do remember me."

"No... I don't know you," Yun Yin said. "What... what do you want?"

"Kill you?" Liang Shi asked lightly in return, and Yun Yin shuddered in fright.

Liang Shi curved her lips in a slight smile as the blade gleamed, looking just like the real thing.

Yun Yin retreated further back, looking ridiculous.

But Liang Shi advanced step by step, spinning the knife in her hand, "Then you must remember Qiu Zimin."

Yun Yin didn't speak.

Seeing that he was frightened enough, Liang Shi softened her voice to reassure him, "Don't be nervous. I just want to ask you a few questions. If you answer me honestly, I'll let you go."

Yun Yin's eyes lit up, but the next second, Liang Shi's knife landed on his neck, right at the position of his carotid artery, pressing down lightly, "Otherwise, this knife will cut right through your throat."

As if afraid Yun Yin wouldn't believe her, she curved her lips in a cold smile and said, "Don't think I can't do it. Don't forget, I'm someone who even lived in that coffin room² you set up."

"Also..." Liang Shi leaned in close and said in a low voice, "I'm dying."

Yun Yin's eyes widened immediately, "How... how can that be?"

"Didn't you transfer my fortune³ to Dongheng?" Liang Shi said seriously. "Dongheng is flourishing more and more each day, and a few days ago when I went to the hospital, I was diagnosed with cancer."

Yun Yin: "....."

"Impossible!" Yun Yin said. "You got sick on your own! What does that have to do with transferring fortune?"

Liang Shi chuckled softly, "Is that so? But I also have a mental illness."

Yun Yin: "....."

Faced with this statement, Yun Yin didn't dare make another sound.

Liang Shi's blade pressed closer to his neck, "Tell me, what normal person wouldn't go insane if they were thrown into that kind of room? How about I throw you in there to stay for a few days?"

"No, no, no." Yun Yin denied repeatedly.

Liang Shi then stared directly at him.

A deadly sense of oppression washed over him. Yun Yin's head trembled slightly, and when his skin touched the ice-cold blade, he immediately backed away.

Footnotes:

¹ **Immortal, otherworldly demeanor (仙風道骨):** A Chinese idiom describing someone who has the ethereal, mystical bearing of a Daoist immortal—suggesting wisdom, grace, and detachment from worldly concerns. Often used to describe Daoist priests or elderly sages.

² **Coffin room:** Refers to the specially arranged room that Qiu Zimin (the original host's adoptive mother) had Yun Yin set up using feng shui principles to supposedly harm the original host. The room was designed with sinister elements meant to negatively affect the occupant's fortune and mental state.

³ **Fortune/luck transfer (換氣運):** A superstitious concept in Chinese folk belief where one person's luck or fortune can supposedly be transferred to another person through mystical means. This is what Qiu Zimin allegedly paid Yun Yin to do—transfer the original host's fortune to Dongheng (a company).

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Liang Shi continued, "Also, when a mentally ill person kills someone—it seems like it's not against the law."

Yun Yin immediately panicked, "Wait, wait... I'll talk."

"Then talk." Liang Shi moved the knife back a bit, reducing some of the pressure. "Tell me properly—how exactly did you and Qiu Zimin discuss things? Is the thing about using a person as a sacrifice to transfer fortune real?"

"How could it possibly be real?" Yun Yin was on the verge of tears, terrified of being stabbed to death by the person in front of him. After all, he was partly responsible for her current state of madness. He had been hiding and not daring to see her afterward, precisely because he was afraid this madwoman wouldn't go settle accounts with Qiu Zimin but would come find him instead. In the end, no matter how much he dodged left and right, he still couldn't escape.

"It's all fake!" Yun Yin said. "You... you're at least someone who's been to school. Don't you know that feudal superstitions are unacceptable?!"

Liang Shi sneered coldly, "Then why do you go around reading feng shui¹ for people?"

Yun Yin: "...Forced by circumstances."

Yun Yin extended two fingers, carefully pinching Liang Shi's knife and pushing it away. "L-Liang Shi, y-y-you put this thing away, and I'll tell you everything."

He spoke with a stutter. Liang Shi spun the knife in her hand once, then folded it up and put it away.

Liang Shi's hands were so pale they glowed white under the sun, casually resting on her legs. "So you do remember me after all."

"Of course." Yun Yin said, "You're the most pitiful person I've ever seen."

Liang Shi: "?"

For a moment, she didn't know what this person was getting at.²

"I said back then that transferring fortune is extremely mysterious and enigmatic—it can't be done," Yun Yin said. "It was your mother who said it could be transferred. I... I only said those things for the money. And that room of yours—it was your mother who came to me with the plans and asked me to set it up. That sculpture too—your mother also wanted that done."

Liang Shi sneered, "So the fortune transfer thing was fake?"

"Definitely." Yun Yin said with certainty, "If I could transfer fortune for people, I... I would have transferred myself into the world's richest person long ago."

Liang Shi's gaze turned cold, "Then why did you help Qiu Zimin?"

Yun Yin's expression suddenly changed as he looked at her—as if to say she clearly didn't understand the hardships of life.

"For money, of course." Yun Yin said, "Your mother said as long as I did what she told me, she'd give me two million."

Liang Shi asked, "And then you used that money to build the Yun Yin Daoist Temple?"

Yun Yin nodded, "Your mother also introduced me to some work afterward, plus what I've saved up over the years..."

Liang Shi interrupted him, "So you've been deceiving people all these years?"

"Well, not exactly..." Yun Yin paused, then said sheepishly, "Not entirely. Some things... do have a bit of metaphysics to them."

"For example?" Liang Shi asked.

Yun Yin said, "You... you actually don't have much fortune."

Liang Shi frowned.

Yun Yin said, "Your fate chart³ is too complex. I can't... can't read it clearly, but you have a naturally wealthy and noble appearance."

His words were incoherent and contradictory. Liang Shi scoffed lightly, "Enough, stop making things up to save your life. Let me ask you again—why did Qiu Zimin have that kind of room set up for me?"

Yun Yin was surprised, "You don't know?"

Liang Shi: "...I don't."

"Then I don't know either." Yun Yin spread his hands, "If even you don't know, how would I know?"

Liang Shi: "....."

A cold light flashed in her eyes, and the folding knife once again revealed its sharp blade, "Don't give me that smooth talk."

"I... I really don't know." Yun Yin said, "She paid me to do a job. How would I know what she wanted to do?"

"Then do you dare guarantee that everything you've said today is true?" Liang Shi asked.

Yun Yin paused for a moment, "If I've lied, may heaven strike me with lightning."⁴

¹ **Feng shui (風水):** An ancient Chinese practice of arranging spaces and objects to achieve harmony with the environment. Literally meaning "wind-water," it involves the placement of buildings, furniture, and other elements to optimize the flow of qi (life energy) and bring good fortune.

² **Didn't know what this person was getting at (不知道這個人葫蘆裏賣得什麼藥):** A Chinese idiom literally meaning "not knowing what medicine is being sold in the gourd." It refers to being unable to figure out someone's true intentions or what they're really trying to say.

³ **Fate chart (命盤):** In Chinese fortune-telling traditions, particularly Zi Wei Dou Shu (Purple Star Astrology) and Bazi (Eight Characters), a fate chart is a diagram that maps out a person's destiny based on their birth date and time. It's used to predict one's fortune, career, relationships, and life events.

⁴ **May heaven strike me with lightning (天打雷劈):** A traditional Chinese oath used to emphasize the truthfulness of one's words. By invoking divine punishment, the speaker swears they are telling the truth, as lying would supposedly invite heavenly retribution in the form of being struck by lightning.

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When Liang Shi returned to the crew again, Yan Xi was the first to see her and asked who she had gone to fight with.

"I was joking. Did you actually believe it?" Liang Shi said casually.

Yan Xi: "...How boring."

Liang Shi sat on a bench. The crew had already resumed normal operations.

It happened to be lunch break, and when Yan Xi went to get boxed meals, she brought one back for her as well. Today's boxed meal was decent—one meat dish, two vegetable dishes, and a soup—just that the rice portion was small.

Liang Shi asked about it, and Yan Xi said, "The director thinks we've been eating too many boxed meals and getting fat, which doesn't look good on camera, so he's having us eat less carbs."

Liang Shi: "....."

The mysterious incidents on set ultimately concluded with a supernatural explanation.

Yan Xi was dismissive of this, "We're people of the new era now. Why would anyone still believe in this kind of stuff? That Daoist priest is obviously just scamming money."

Liang Shi nodded silently beside her.

But whether or not the Daoist priest was scamming money wasn't important. What mattered was that it had calmed everyone's anxious hearts.

Finally, it was no longer like the past few days, where if you stayed in the bathroom a bit too long, you could hear two or three groups of people telling these supernatural stories.

They told them so convincingly that it left everyone feeling listless and dispirited.

Once people were no longer anxious, work efficiency improved.

No matter how you looked at it, the director's thirty thousand yuan was money well spent.

Whether it was psychological or whether this stuff was really somewhat mysterious like the Daoist priest said, who knew.

In any case, the filming afterward went fairly smoothly.

Even if someone in the crew got sick, it was just one person at a time, either from staying up too late or from an old illness relapsing. But there were no more situations like before—getting sick without any warning and being unable to find the cause, ultimately having to blame it all on metaphysics.

From then on, they no longer heard crew members talking about supernatural incidents they or their friends had encountered. But what followed was everyone making plans to visit Yunfeng Mountain together.

Liang Shi heard about it a few times but had no particular thoughts.

However, two days later, Zhao Ying knocked on Liang Shi's door during break time.

That day happened to have no scenes for Zhao Ying. It should have been a pleasant rest day, but there were heavy dark circles under her eyes. After entering Liang Shi's room, she first gulped down several mouthfuls of water, then sat on that cheap wooden chair and said, "I can't take it anymore."

Liang Shi was surprised, "What's wrong?"

Zhao Ying closed her eyes briefly and let out a light breath, "Shu Yi definitely has a mental illness."

Liang Shi: "?"

"She knocked on my door last night and pinned me down and beat me." As Zhao Ying spoke, she lifted her bangs to reveal a three-centimeter wound on her forehead.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi immediately went to rummage through her suitcase. Before she could ask what exactly was going on with Shu Yi, she was already looking for her portable first-aid kit while saying, "Why didn't you treat the wound?"

Zhao Ying sighed, "My whole body has gone numb."

Liang Shi: "....."

She first helped Zhao Ying treat the wound on her forehead. It looked like it had been scratched by something sharp, but it wasn't serious—it had already scabbed over by now.

While Liang Shi was disinfecting it, Zhao Ying sucked in several sharp breaths of cold air, speaking weakly, "This has nothing to do with ghosts or monsters. It's purely that Shu Yi has a mental illness."

"I filmed with her this morning and didn't notice any problems," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Ying was in so much pain that the hand pressing down on her hair was clenching hard, "That's the most outrageous part."

"She knocked on my door at two in the morning last night. She scared me so much I'm about to have a nervous breakdown." Zhao Ying said, "Two in the morning! I was in the middle of a dream... Can you even imagine?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Just hearing about it felt suffocating.

"I can't continue filming this drama." After Liang Shi applied a bandage, Zhao Ying let her bangs down, "Either she goes or I go."

Zhao Ying pressed on her temples, "I've been playing the Great Compassion Mantra¹ before bed now, but I never expected that the real disaster would be man-made!"²

Liang Shi didn't know how to comfort her. Seeing that Zhao Ying was completely out of sorts, she must have been tormented quite badly.

"Before I worked with Shu Yi, I heard this person was pretty decent." Zhao Ying complained in a rambling manner, "Why didn't anyone tell me she sleepwalks and has a mental illness?"

"If she doesn't get treatment soon, I'm going to become mentally ill!" Zhao Ying said.

If this had happened before the drama started filming, everything could have been negotiated.

Given Zhao Ying's current status in the industry, she could just say she didn't have time in her schedule and make arrangements with the director for the next project. Although the director would be unhappy about it, he would give her that courtesy.

But now Zhao Ying had already filmed nearly half of her scenes, and the same was true for Shu Yi.

Replacing an actor at this point—unless the actor had caused a huge scandal that would affect the drama's broadcast, or had been directly blacklisted by the media—was not something anyone would choose to do.

Even if they wanted to replace an actor, they would have to recheck actor schedules, which was very troublesome.

So once many dramas were put on hold, who knew when they would resume filming—it could be ages.³

Most just naturally waited for the project to fall through.

But "Mo Guang"⁴ was a big production. The director was aiming for major awards next year.

Two Best Actress winners, a director who had made multiple bids for international awards—even during the preparation stage, who knew how many celebrities had been brought in. It was practically a dream role that everyone in the industry wanted.

If something went wrong midway, it would definitely cause a stir in the industry.

Footnotes:

¹ **Great Compassion Mantra (大悲咒):** A Buddhist dharani (chant) associated with the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara. In Chinese folk belief, playing or reciting this mantra is thought to ward off evil spirits and provide protection, which is why Zhao Ying plays it before bed to calm her nerves.

² The original text has a censored portion (□□) which likely contained words that were filtered by the publishing platform. Based on context, the sentence means she didn't expect the disaster to be caused by a person rather than supernatural forces.

³ **Who knew when—it could be ages (不知猴年馬月):** A Chinese expression literally meaning "who knows which year of the monkey or month of the horse," referring to an indefinitely long time in the future. It's used when something is delayed with no clear end date in sight.

⁴ **"Mo Guang" (餘光):** The title of the drama being filmed. It translates to "Afterglow" or "Lingering Light."

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Zhao Ying had wanted to finish filming this drama smoothly and steadily. After Shu Yi's initial incident, Zhao Ying's condition had begun to decline rapidly.

She was already quite good at enduring.

But after last night's episode, she felt that if she kept enduring any longer, by the time the drama finished filming, she would need to check herself into a psychiatric hospital first.

There was no one on set she could talk to, so she held it in all morning before finally giving in and coming to find Liang Shi.

Liang Shi listened quietly until she finished, guessed that she hadn't eaten, and handed her a small bread roll.

Zhao Ying was surprised, "How do you have everything here?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"I'm used to it," Liang Shi said. "I often get hungry in the middle of the night when filming."

Zhao Ying felt like she was a treasure chest, equipped with everything one could need.

"You don't seem like this is your first time on set at all." Zhao Ying tore off a piece of the bread and ate it. "Your small suitcase has everything."

Hearing this, Liang Shi shrugged and deliberately tried to lighten the mood, "Maybe I've been on set in my dreams."

Zhao Ying immediately stopped her, "Hold it! I'm scared of the word 'dream' now."

Liang Shi: "....."

What Zhao Ying needed was just someone to talk to, and Liang Shi played that role well.

After eating a small bread roll in Liang Shi's room and drinking a bottle of sports drink, Zhao Ying finally felt her condition improving somewhat.

After some thought, she asked Liang Shi again, "Do you think I should endure or leave?"

Liang Shi hesitated, "Which one are you more inclined toward?"

Like kicking a ball back, she tossed the question right back.

Her answer was watertight.

It wasn't really Liang Shi's fault.

She didn't have any true friends in the industry before—they were basically all casual acquaintances. As for how close they were, it really wasn't that close.

But when she had new dramas airing, there were quite a few people who helped promote them.

Every time she was on a set, she got along well with people. She could basically make two or three friends per drama, but that was limited to while on set and during promotions.

Normally, she kept a low profile.¹

Moreover, Sister Wang had warned her that there were no true friends in this industry.

Everyone was basically in it for mutual benefit, including Sister Wang.

People came together because their interests aligned. When it came to competing for resources, betrayal and drama were unavoidable.

So Liang Shi had developed the habit of speaking carefully and leaving no openings.

After answering Zhao Ying, she felt it was somewhat inadequate, so she added, "If you really feel like you can't hold on, then take a break first. Go on vacation, and when your condition improves, come back to film your parts in a concentrated period."

"The main thing is that looking at Shu Yi now gives me the creeps." Zhao Ying said, "I simply can't act with her. When I think of the look in her eyes last night, I want to cry."

Zhao Ying let out a light breath and couldn't help saying, "I keep thinking, what idiot would fall in love with that kind of psycho?! It's completely masochistic, okay?"

Liang Shi: "....."

From Zhao Ying's words, she could feel deep despair.

Liang Shi comforted her with a few words. Because she still had scenes to film—night scenes at that—she went to the crew first to get her makeup and hair done, leaving Zhao Ying alone to rest in the hotel.

Zhao Ying didn't want to go back to her own room, afraid of encountering Shu Yi having another episode, so Liang Shi let her stay in her room.

That night, Zhao Ying switched rooms and slept next door to Yan Xi.

And so, that night, it was said that the people staying on Shu Yi's floor heard knocking sounds for half the night.

A producer came out to check and was so frightened they lost bladder control.

Shu Yi was wearing a white spaghetti-strap nightgown, with a wig she had gotten from who knows where hanging straight down, knocking on Zhao Ying's door.

Like a female ghost straight out of a horror movie.

Everyone on that floor who came out saw that scene, including the director.

When Zhao Ying heard from the director the next day, she secretly celebrated that she had listened to Liang Shi's advice and changed her sleeping location. Otherwise, based on the producer's description, she might not have just lost bladder control—she might have had a heart attack and been sent straight to the hospital.

With her vivid imagination, just hearing about it made her scalp tingle, as if she had experienced it herself.

Zhao Ying still brought it up with the director, saying she couldn't continue working with Shu Yi.

Although she had said in school that she could sacrifice herself for art, she didn't want it to be this kind of death.

If word got out, people would laugh their teeth off.

The director hadn't seen Shu Yi like that before and had thought everyone was being alarmist. But this time he had seen it with his own eyes, and the level of horror was enough to frighten even him—someone who had previously directed horror films.

No wonder Zhao Ying had been out of sorts for so long.

The director nodded wearily, "I'll consider it."

Zhao Ying: "....."

Seeing that he was still hesitating, Zhao Ying said bluntly, "There's no way I'm acting with her anymore. Looking at her face feels like watching a horror movie. How am I supposed to act like I'm in love with her? Maybe in the next life."

The director: "If..."

"There are no ifs." Zhao Ying was always straightforward—once she made a decision, she didn't hesitate. "I've already endured several times. If I could still hold on, I wouldn't have brought this up with you. You've seen what Shu Yi is like, and you know what I was like when I filmed before. If it really doesn't work out, let's terminate the contract. I'll pay you the penalty fee, and we'll work together on the next drama."

The director: "....."

This directly backed the director into a corner with no way out.

He also knew that Zhao Ying was truly desperate.

After what happened that night, daytime filming naturally came to a halt.

Footnotes:

¹ **Kept a low profile (神隱狀態):** The term "神隱" (shen yin) literally means "hidden by the gods" and refers to someone who disappears from public view or maintains an extremely low profile. It's often used to describe celebrities who stay out of the spotlight when not working.

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Yan Xi even joked with Liang Shi, "This crew really has bad feng shui."

Liang Shi didn't feel much about it. She had encountered plenty of unlucky crews before. Some had already filmed to the end when suddenly news broke that the male lead had been arrested for drug use.

Others had finished filming and were in the promotion period when the female lead's relationship was exposed.

And that female lead just happened to be an idol on the rise.

There were also situations like her previous one, where after the promotion period ended and the drama finished airing, one party went crazy stepping on the other.

One could only say that in this industry, those who survived were subject to survivorship bias.

Only one in ten dramas made it before the public eye. The rest either died along the way or were cut off halfway.

During this day of rest, the director made a decision—to replace Shu Yi.

But how to discuss this with Shu Yi was also a problem.

Shu Yi's agent insisted adamantly that Shu Yi had no mental illness. If the director labeled her here, he would probably be cursed by fans until he couldn't recognize his own mother.

He could only bring it up tactfully.

So the director decided to use the universal excuse—you're great, but not quite right for this role.

However, before the director could go find Shu Yi, trending topics related to Shu Yi exploded online—Shu Yi Drug Addict.

—Shu Yi's Studio Needs to Pay 370 Million in Back Taxes

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These trending topics exploded without warning.

And on the same day, also on the trending list was Chen Liuying, who was attempting a comeback.

It's just that her entry seemed insignificant under Shu Yi's topics.

Before, many people had gone to curse at Chen Liuying, but today everyone was busy eating Shu Yi's melon¹, and no one had time to pay attention to her.

So her set of risqué "artistic photos" went unappreciated.

The occasional few comments were:

[If you didn't know better, you'd think you'd arrived at an adult shop.]

[Art is just a fig leaf. Hope you have one.]

[Have you really not considered going into the adult film industry?]

[Don't say that, I suspect she's already filming them.]

[The level of exposure in these photos is more than what I see in adult films.]

[Miss, how much for one night?]

[.....]

They were all very vulgar comments.

But Chen Liuying's photo set was indeed vulgar to begin with. The amount of fabric on her body was pathetically small—it wasn't a normal artistic photo shoot at all.

If it had been about breaking conventions with creativity and a theme, that would have been fine, but it was purely just to show off her figure.

[Does this lady really think this can trick female fans?]

[Why do I feel like she wants to hook up with fans?]

[Wasn't there news before that she slept with fans? Indeed, the internet has no memory.]

[.....]

A new wave of discussion erupted in the comments section, but the attention and engagement were too low.

Yet somehow even with this kind of data, it could get on the trending list, and in the top spots too.

Anyone with eyes could tell it was bought.

The hashtag #Chen Liuying So Beautiful# even briefly stayed at the number one trending spot for a while, but unexpectedly, within just a few minutes, Shu Yi's topic dropped from the sky onto the trending list, then raced to the top at lightning speed, directly crushing Chen Liuying's hashtag.

The news that Shu Yi was a drug addict was exposed by her ex-wife.

So along with it came the hashtag #Shu Yi Secret Marriage#.

No matter what, Shu Yi was still a Best Actress winner, although her Best Actress title was only a domestic award with not much prestige.

But she was quite good at attracting fans, with over seventy million Weibo followers. Among mainland young actresses, her traffic was considered high.

And her image had always been that of a pure, gentle girl-next-door type. No one expected such news to suddenly break, leaving everyone stunned.

Netizens were like badgers² bouncing around in a melon field.

In her ex-wife's exposé post, she wrote that Shu Yi had a mild tendency toward domestic violence and would hit people while sleepwalking. At first, she thought Shu Yi was mentally affected by losing her mother, so the ex-wife forgave her. But unexpectedly, she got worse and worse, and the ex-wife couldn't help but bring up divorce.

The two of them had been classmates for many years, dated for eight years, then entered the halls of marriage.

For the sake of Shu Yi's career, the wife had always chosen to keep their marriage secret. They never had a wedding ceremony, no proposal, and even after marriage, they rarely saw each other.

The entire post was almost entirely an accusation of Shu Yi's misdeeds, vastly different from the Shu Yi who usually appeared in front of cameras. People simply couldn't believe it.

So initially, Shu Yi's fans went crazy cursing in the comment section.

They cursed her for slander, for clout-chasing, and for being desperate for fame.

Some even directly cursed her whole family to die a horrible death.

Then Shu Yi's ex-wife posted another blog entry. The gist was that she herself had studied auditing and had secretly investigated Shu Yi's studio finances before reporting them to the tax authorities, which were currently under investigation.

Before long, the tax authority's investigation results came out, directly confirming Shu Yi's tax evasion.

Shu Yi's trending status remained sky-high, even dragging Zhao Ying and the "Mo Guang" crew into it.

The hashtag #Feel Sorry For Zhao Ying# was also trending high. Zhao Ying directly posted on Weibo: Still alive, haven't gone crazy, don't want to ride on someone's coattails for attention, thank you all for your concern, but it's really not necessary.

A complete and thorough rejection.

Zhao Ying's attitude toward this person was made clear online.

When the director went to find Shu Yi again, he couldn't find her anymore. Shu Yi had been arrested by the police and taken away for a blood test.

Footnotes:

¹ **Eating melons (吃瓜):** Chinese internet slang for watching drama unfold or following gossip as a bystander. The term comes from the image of people casually eating watermelon while watching events unfold, similar to eating popcorn while watching a movie.

² **Badgers bouncing around in a melon field (在瓜田裏上蹿下跳的獾):** A reference to a famous scene from Lu Xun's short story "Hometown" (故鄉), where a character describes catching badgers (獾, chá) that raid watermelon fields. Here it's used humorously to describe netizens excitedly jumping from one piece of gossip to another, like badgers running wild in a melon field.

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Liang Shi saw Chen Liuying while scrolling through Shu Yi's trending topics. Her intention to test the waters for a comeback during this period was exceptionally obvious.

But every time, she got cut off.

Liang Shi felt that Chen Liuying's entertainment industry luck was truly terrible.

First there were natural disasters, then man-made calamities.

Her luck was mediocre, and she kept making things worse for herself. Every time she wanted to spend money to buy a high-ranking trending topic, she would get pushed down by someone else in a short time.

Liang Shi also hadn't forgotten that Chen Liuying was quite a key character in the original novel. Because she admired Xu Qingzhu, she had dug out the glands of the original host—the cannon fodder first wife.

But that was built on the premise that Chen Liuying was a superstar in the entertainment industry worth tens of millions, while the original host had fallen from grace and been exposed as not being the real heiress. Now, Chen Liuying was like a stray dog, and Liang Shi hadn't fallen from grace either.

Although Liang Shi couldn't figure out why someone who admired Xu Qingzhu would end up with Xu Qingzhu's former best friend Bai Weiwei, the system had said that the major events in this world wouldn't change.

Liang Shi felt that the event of the original host having her glands dug out would still happen—right when Chen Liuying turned dark.

Liang Shi even began to suspect that the key event the system mentioned triggering was for her to have her glands dug out by Chen Liuying, which would then soften Xu Qingzhu's heart and bring the luck value to one hundred.

Besides this, Liang Shi really couldn't think of anything else.

Liang Shi was different from the original host—she had the ability to protect herself, so she wasn't too afraid.

However, since Chen Liuying was now in the shadows while she was in the open, she still remained vigilant.

The closer she got to the mission completion deadline, the stronger Liang Shi's inner unease became.

But life still went on as usual. The Shu Yi incident stayed on the trending list for two or three days. This person had committed too many offenses at once—there was no way she could make a comeback.

What awaited her was certainly legal sanctions.

As for the director, being someone with standards for his work, he inevitably couldn't find a suitable actress in such a short time, so the crew's filming was suspended.

All the early investments had gone down the drain.

The date for resuming filming was undetermined.

The director drank himself into a stupor for several days because of this, looking utterly haggard.

The day after Zhao Ying learned the news, she directly had her assistant drive her back to the city, saying she was going home to catch up on sleep.

She absolutely had to make up for all the sleep she'd lost.

Liang Shi felt sorry for the crew's efforts and also for these characters.

But there was nothing that could be done about it. Looking on the bright side, it was discovered midway through filming, not after filming was complete or during the promotion period. The script could still be used, and with some modifications, the show could still air. At worst, they'd lose a few million, but as long as they followed up properly, they could still break even.

The scariest scenario would have been if all of Shu Yi's issues exploded the day before airing—then the entire crew's labor would have gone down the drain.

As one of the female leads, the drama would have been impossible to air.

This was probably the only thing to be thankful for.

But Shu Yi had scared everyone in the crew badly. They all felt like they had seen a ghost.

Although Liang Shi hadn't seen it with her own eyes, just hearing their vivid descriptions gave her nightmares for two nights straight.

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After confirming the filming suspension, Yan Xi returned to school.

Liang Shi was among the later ones to leave. She was busy looking at Chen Liuying's suppressed trending topics and used a secondary account to follow Chen Liuying's updates.

She always felt uneasy deep down.

After learning that Chen Liuying had a secondary account, Liang Shi followed that one too.

But her secondary account only posted peaceful, idyllic content—things like sunshine, coffee, fallen leaves, as well as her own fitness photos and vlogs.

After everyone gradually left the crew one after another, Liang Shi finally packed up and left.

She drove back to the city, but when she reached the Yujiang Bridge, she received a call from an unknown number.

"Hello?" Liang Shi greeted politely and put the phone on speaker.

The car crossed the Yujiang Bridge, just steps away from her home.

The other end of the phone was unusually quiet. Liang Shi sensed something was wrong and immediately asked, "Hello?"

There was only weak breathing on the phone. Then that obscure, hoarse voice said, "Liang Shi, call the police."

It was Gu Xingyue!

"How are you?" Liang Shi asked. "What happened?"

"Yang Jiani killed someone." Gu Xingyue's voice seemed to come from the clouds, so faint it was almost inaudible.

"Serial murder." Gu Xingyue repeated these four characters, then hung up.

Just hearing this made Liang Shi's heart pound with fear. Her hands on the steering wheel were unsteady. She couldn't worry about going home anymore. She quickly pulled the car over to the side of the road and immediately dialed 110¹, and also called 120² for emergency services.

A few seconds later, she called Chen Mian on WeChat.

Chen Mian seemed to have been sleeping on her end. After answering, her voice was hoarse. Liang Shi let out a light breath and said, "Do you know any good lawyers?"

Chen Mian was surprised, "Hm?"

Although Liang Shi's voice was trembling, it carried a hint of excitement, "Gu Xingyue... that is, the current Qi Jiao, has made her move."

Footnotes:

¹ **110:** The police emergency number in China, equivalent to 911 in the United States.

² **120:** The medical emergency number in China for ambulance services.

Chapter 121-7

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Liang Shi had never expected Gu Xingyue to carry out her revenge in such a way that would harm the enemy a thousand times while harming herself eight hundred.¹

She had thought Gu Xingyue would set up an elaborate scheme to bring Yang Jiani to justice.

On the way driving to the Qi residence, Liang Shi was still wondering whether Qi Jiao had gotten Yang Jiani arrested at the cost of harming herself.

But Gu Xingyue had also said four words—serial murder.

Serial...

Who else was there?

Liang Shi was puzzled, and although she was worried about Gu Xingyue, she didn't think anything would happen to her.

Since she had done it, Gu Xingyue must have been confident.

On the way to the Qi residence, Liang Shi kept thinking this way.

After calling the police, she had provided the specific crime location. By the time she arrived at the Qi residence, a police cordon had already been set up. Chen Mian arrived at almost the same time as her.

Chen Mian was wearing a black silk blouse, a very thin one that looked a bit cold.

She was also wearing glasses with dark blue frames that matched her hair color well.

The tear mole beneath her cold eyes made her appear extremely aloof, yet when she asked Liang Shi, it betrayed her nervousness, "What happened?"

Liang Shi said, "I don't know yet. She only called to have me report to the police."

Being able to have Liang Shi call the police without explaining anything showed complete trust in Liang Shi's ability to handle things.

Yet Liang Shi was still completely confused.

She went forward to ask the police officer standing inside the cordon what the situation was inside.

The officer's expression was serious: "No comment."

"Is there a girl inside?" Liang Shi asked. "The injured one—has she been taken for treatment?"

The police officer became wary, "Who are you?"

Liang Shi introduced herself, "Officer, I'm the one who reported this. I received a call from my friend and called the police. You can check my call records. I just want to know if my friend is okay."

The officer looked suspiciously at her phone and said coldly, "Wait here."

Before long, someone who appeared to be a leader came out. After looking Liang Shi and Chen Mian up and down, he asked, "Who is the person who reported this?"

"Me." Liang Shi asked, "What about my friend? Is she injured?"

"She's already been taken into surgery," the other party said coldly.

Liang Shi: "....."

It was this serious?

Just as Liang Shi wanted to ask more, two people brought out Yang Jiani with her hair disheveled.

Yang Jiani was wearing handcuffs, with blood all over her hands and body. Only when she saw Liang Shi did a glimmer of light appear in her eyes—but it was dark and sinister, frightening.

She was nothing like her former elegant self.

Before, even if her heart was black, she was very refined as a person. No matter when you looked at her, she seemed like she had walked out of an old Republican-era film², naturally carrying an air of grace.

But today, she was a complete and utter madwoman.

As she passed by Liang Shi, she threatened, "Liang Shi, I told you—if you made me lose another daughter, I would definitely kill you!"

As she spoke, she began to struggle, but she didn't have enough strength. The handcuffs rubbed her wrists raw, bleeding continuously.

Yang Jiani seemed to feel nothing at all.

Liang Shi took a step back, but her gaze remained fixed directly on her. Her hands clenched into fists at her sides. "Officer! I have another report to make!"

The police officer standing to the side looked at her with confusion.

Liang Shi let out a light breath and said word by word, "Yang Jiani killed her daughter, Qi Jiao."

Footnotes:

¹ **Harm the enemy a thousand times while harming herself eight hundred (殺敵一千自損八百):** A Chinese idiom describing a pyrrhic victory—achieving one's goal but at great personal cost. It means that while you may defeat your enemy, you also suffer significant losses yourself.

² **Republican-era film (民國舊電影):** Refers to films from or depicting China's Republican era (1912-1949). This period is often romanticized in Chinese media, associated with elegant women in qipao dresses, sophisticated aesthetics, and a particular refined charm that blended traditional Chinese and Western influences.